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Experience, Expertise, and Strategic
Diversification: How Professional
Background Shapes Legislative
Behavior in China's National
People's Congress

By

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Abstract

The study tests the functional co-optation theory and reputation-boost theory against different delegate types in Chinese National People's Congress, analyzing an original dataset of 622 delegates who sponsored at least one bill in the 13th NPC (2018-2022) and their 2,209 sponsored bills. Building on content analysis and logistic models, I find that functional delegates increasingly sponsor professionally congruent bills as they gain seniority (supporting the co-optation theory), while non-functional delegates, particularly CEOs, increasingly diversify beyond their professional domains as they gain seniority (supporting the reputation-boost theory). These divergent patterns remain robust when controlling for demographic factors, with female government executives uniquely sponsoring professionally congruent bills addressing women's interests, while ethnic minorities in non-functional roles demonstrate lower professional congruence than their Han counterparts. These findings reveal authoritarian legislatures as complex arenas where delegates leverage professional expertise, political considerations, and demographic representation to maximize their policy influence. To the best of my knowledge, this article is the first to link professional backgrounds to bill subject matter in an authoritarian setting, offering insights into delegate behavior in the absence of electoral accountability.

Keywords: Authoritarian legislature, Legislative behavior, Professional congruence, Chinese National People's Congress

Introduction

Due to the lack of electoral accountability, authoritarian regimes face great challenges in accessing public attitudes, especially public discontent (Wintrobe, 1998; Brownlee, 2007; Manion, 2008). Being aloof to the discontent raises the likelihood of public unrest, posing threats to regime stability (Lorentzen, 2013; Manion, 2015). A branch of literature points to legislatures as a platform for mitigating the challenges (Gandhi & Lust-Okar, 2009; Gandhi, 2010; Malesky & Schuler, 2010a). Given that even highly flawed elections are associated with some degree of responsiveness to underlying constituencies (Manin, Stokes, & Przeworski, 1999), within expectations, this branch of literature offers explanations that primarily rely on effective representation through elections. These explanations imply that legislatures without elections are of little use in addressing the information-collection problem in an authoritarian setting.

However, this notion contradicts the evidence that reveals a vibrant dynamic in authoritarian legislatures. For one, the Chinese National People's Congress (NPC), the highest level of legislature in China, commonly recognized as a rubber stamp Congress (Truex, 2014), received 16,000 more bills between 1983 and 2007. Moreover, the law-making process was surprisingly selective. Among the sponsored bills, only 486 bills were promulgated (Lü, Liu, & Li, 2020). The dynamic raises a series of questions. What determines the subject matter of a bill in the absence of electoral accountability? Why do delegates sponsor bills that are irrelevant to their interests to a single-party legislature? Most importantly, in the face of a low acceptance rate, what drives Chinese legislators to even sponsor bills?¹

¹ I use legislators, delegates, and bill sponsors interchangeably to indicate individuals who are eligible to submit bills to a legislature. I use legislature and congress interchangeably to indicate the institution that possesses the legislative power in a regime.

Finding out answers to these questions is important. Single-party regimes appear to be the most resilient among dictatorships (Slater, 2003; Smith, 2005; Brownlee, 2007; Magaloni, 2008). Given that information provision is empirically linked to regime longevity (Geddes, 2006), probing its underlying mechanism in the absence of electoral contests fills a major gap in studies on single-party regimes and authoritarian regimes in general. To the best of my knowledge, this article is the first to link professional backgrounds to bill subject matter in an authoritarian setting, offering insights into delegate behavior in the absence of electoral accountability.

The article tests the functional co-optation theory and reputation-boost theory against different delegate types in China's NPC, analyzing an original dataset of 622 delegates who sponsored at least one bill in the 13th NPC (2018-2022) and their 2,209 sponsored bills. Building on content analysis and logistic models, I find that functional delegates increasingly sponsor professionally congruent bills with experience (supporting the co-optation theory), while non-functional delegates, particularly CEOs, increasingly diversify beyond their professional domains as they gain seniority (supporting the reputation-boost theory). These divergent patterns remain robust when controlling for demographic factors, with female government executives uniquely sponsoring professionally congruent bills addressing women's interests, while ethnic minorities in non-functional roles demonstrate lower professional congruence than their Han counterparts. These findings reveal authoritarian legislatures as complex arenas where delegates strategically navigate professional expertise, political considerations, and demographic representation to maximize their policy influence.

In what follows, I first evaluate the predictions made by the co-optation theory and the reputation-boost theory on what type of information delegates might provide and what drives them to do so.

Second, I introduce background information on Chinese NPC and the NPC delegates, before giving a brief summary on China's legislative process. Third, I summarize the research design and data collection before testing the effect of delegates' terms in office on the subject matter of their sponsored bills. The final section concludes with the implications of the findings on authoritarian legislatures as an information-collection platform and three questions for future research in the study of authoritarian political institutions.

Delegates' Motivations in the Absence of Elections

Among the current studies, the co-optation theory (Malesky & Schuler, 2010b) and the reputation-boost theory (Truex, 2016) offer the clearest predictions on what type of information delegates provide and what drives them to do so.

The co-optation theory

In the co-optation view, delegates represent the interests of the co-opted outside groups (Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2005; Lust-Okar, 2006; Gandhi & Przeworski 2006). Through elections, a regime identifies influential members from opposition parties. The members, driven by limited policy influence or access to rents, then reveal demands in the legislature. However, in political settings where opposition parties are proscribed and elections prohibited, such as China, Cuba, or Vietnam, whom to co-opt is less obvious.

Malesky and Schuler (2010b, p. 485) suggests three potential alternatives. In a legislature without competition of any kind, regimes are likely to co-opt local notables in important provinces or districts, influential religious or ethnic leaders, or to perform functional co-optation – capturing prominent business leaders or military across geographic borders. A critical assumption to the

suggestion is that these people are potential key figures in society. They may be capable of influencing and mobilizing citizens, and in turn, leading regime-threatening activities. To avoid such activities, delegates are expected to provide information that indicates policy positions that reflect the interests of the co-opted outsiders they have been selected to represent. Therefore, evaluations of the above variations on the co-optation theory should take place in political settings where some of the above groups are capable of shaping the political landscape.

Unfortunately, China is not an appropriate case to test the first two variations. Being one of the most enduring autocratic regimes today (Song & Wright, 2018), Chinese Communist Party's (CCP) China is not under major threat of secession at the subnational level.² In addition, there exist no religious or ethnic forces in the regime that are as influential as in Saddam's Iraq or in Suharto's Indonesia.

Nonetheless, the Chinese national legislature shows characteristics that seem to agree with the predictions proffered by the functional co-optation theory. The regime carefully orchestrated its national legislature by selecting delegates from different age groups, religious groups, professions, and economic sectors (O'Brien, 2008). The purpose of the orchestration is to "deliberately arrange for a balance of various social sectors and interests" (Jiang, 2003). This suggests the possibility of the functional co-optation theory in practice. Namely, the regime may co-opt key figures across various sectors and professions into the legislature with the hope of them revealing demands by advancing policies – an institutionalized manner of asserting demands – to prevent potential regime-threatening events.

² Major attempts at secession have concentrated in Xinjiang and Tibet since the birth of the CCP regime. Yet they all have been suppressed immediately. For the attempts in Xinjiang, see a comprehensive assessment by Millward (2004); For the attempts in Tibet, see Schaik (2013, Chap. 8).

In addition to preventing public unrest, another advantage brought by the functional co-optation strategy is the influence of expertise across various sectors and professions on state governance. As argued by Schmitter (1974, p. 111), the pattern of sectoral interest representation benefits a modern state by providing professional expertise, specialized information and prior aggregation of opinion through policy advancement. For instance, in the Vietnamese National Assembly, delegates from functional backgrounds such as research institutes, private enterprise, and law firms tend to be the most active speakers and ask questions pertaining to functional expertise to hold the dominant party accountable (Malesky & Schuler, 2010b). The benefit is even more substantial in democratic contexts, with empirical evidence from the U.S. Congress shows that bills are more likely to progress in the legislative process when the sponsor's professional background matches the bill's policy area (Makse, 2021). Hence, if the functional co-optation theory stands in the Chinese context, we should expect dictators to demand expertise from delegates by having them advance policies that exhibit professional congruence, i.e., match their professional background.

Moreover, we should expect the tendency to increase, as delegates gain seniority. As demonstrated by Miler (2017), legislators stayed true to issues that they believed deserved their attention at the early stage of their legislator career even after their seniority accrued. If legislators' interests remain an important determinant in the subject matter of a bill even when electoral accountability is in place, it is not hard to imagine them prioritizing the interests of their profession when facing no such institutional barriers. In addition, the tendency is only likely to grow as delegates get more familiarized with legislative expertise. As argued by Miquel and Snyder (2006), legislators master specific legislative skills, such as drafting bills, as they spend more time in legislative work through the "learning-by-doing" mechanism. Therefore, legislators who are more familiarized with these

skills should be more sophisticated in progressing bills through the legislative process. From the most conservative viewpoint, we expect to see the tendencies in delegates with a functional background. Because their professional expertise is clearer to the public than delegates who have non-functional background. The above analysis generates the first hypothesis.

Hypothesis 1. Delegates with functional backgrounds are more likely to advance policies in issue areas that match their professional background. The tendency is likely to increase as delegates serve more terms in office.

The reputation-boost theory

Truex's (2016) reputation-boost theory generates a prediction more likely to be observed in delegates with non-functional backgrounds. . Truex argues that some candidates seek public office for a boost in reputation and benefits that come with their political affiliation. Gaining a seat in the legislature signals connections, confidence and competence to outsiders; in turn, the positive signal attracts more resources to individual candidates in the profession or industry they work in (Truex, 2016, p. 151). So far the theory has only been tested on delegates who are company CEOs, but Truex believes benefits that come with the reputation boost is likely to be salient for other delegates. He suggests that one of the benefits of seeking office could be developing personal relationships and reciprocity behaviors among delegates. As noted in his personal interview with a former NPC delegate: "Here is why people want to be in the congress...it's like being in a big club. Professors, entrepreneurs, officials – everyone becomes good friends over these two years. It's a way to help develop connections" (Truex, 2016, p. 152). What this former NPC delegate suggests is that gaining a seat in the legislature could rapidly attract and concentrate connections, social resources, and economic benefits to individual delegates, and thereby maximizing delegates' collective benefits as a

group. As such, delegates are likely to develop personal connections and engage in reciprocity behaviors across different professional sectors.

The above analysis presents two motivations that can alter delegate behaviors in a legislature. First, delegates are driven by a reputation reboost. If the benefits of being a delegate come with positive external perceptions, the benefits are likely to be gone as the perceptions wear off; probably no later than the announcement of new delegates for the next term. In democratic contexts, earning public support is a proof of competence for legislators. As a result, when legislators demand resources from campaign sponsors to run for higher office, they demonstrate their competence by appealing to a larger and more diverse constituency rather than a single congressional district. In particular, they mitigate their demonstration of policy specialization and display a wide breadth of policy knowledge (Victor, 2010). Even for legislators who simply aim for reelection, in the U.S. Congress, we see them introduce legislation on topics of little familiarity to their professional background and legislative agenda (Herrick, Moore, & Hibbing, 1994).

Likewise, we might imagine that to attract more benefits, delegates in authoritarian settings would rather appeal to a broader crowd by advancing policies that demonstrate their social responsibility than represent sectoral interests of a small group of peers in their professional area. By appealing to a broader public audience, they remind outsiders of their delegate status and the connections and resources they have to exert public influence. In turn, public exposure among the general public reboosts their reputation, and thereby maintains, if not attracts more, benefits that come with the delegate seat. Just as in democratic contexts, demonstrating policy specialization by advancing policies on a specific professional area is not likely to achieve the purpose. Because at this point, it has become an obligation rather than behaviors that deserve rewards.

Second, delegates are driven by developing personal relationships with each other, i.e., experts across different sectors and professions. If personal connections bring solid benefits to delegates, we should be able to observe reciprocity behavior in a legislature where delegates have policy influence – a potential logrolling in an autocratic setting. Logrolling behaviors are widespread in democratic contexts, such as the US (Stratmann, 1995) and EU (Aksoy, 2012). Legislators exchange votes in the legislative negotiation process, attempting to achieve optimal outcomes for all sides involved. However, the voting stage in autocracies is widely considered a formality (Truex, 2014, p. 235). Scholars therefore contend that the process of policy negotiation happens during bill sponsorship, before the voting stage (Lü, Liu, & Li, 2018, p. 1385). If this is the case, making policy proposals could be the more prevailing channel for delegates to engage in reciprocity behaviors. In addition, the behaviors should become more discernible as delegates' relationships consolidate over time.

Unfortunately, we lack public information on co-sponsors for each bill to put the second mechanism under test. Nonetheless, if the first mechanism stands, delegates are likely to advance policies that appear irrelevant to their professional background. They are more likely to do so as their seniority accrues. From the most conservative perspective, we expect delegates with non-functional backgrounds to have these behavioral patterns because their scope of expertise is less clear to the public than delegates with professional backgrounds. This generates the second hypothesis.

Hypothesis 2. Delegates with non-functional backgrounds are more likely to advance policies in issue areas that do not match their professional background. The tendency is likely to increase as delegates serve more terms in office.

In the next section, I will introduce the background information on Chinese NPC before putting the two hypotheses under test.

Background on the NPC and China’s legislative system

The NPC is the highest level of legislature in China. It has the constitutional right to amend the constitution, enact laws, and appoint individuals to national political posts. The full congress has nearly 3,000 members for each term. Each term lasts for five years. Delegates meet once per year in March for a period of two or three weeks to deliberate and vote on bills and policy proposals, as well as to approve budgets, work reports, and leadership appointments. Unlike their democratic counterparts, the majority of NPC delegates work part-time, unpaid, and have no office or personal staff. Just as their democratic counterparts, the number of bills they sponsor each year and the subject matter of the bills are within their discretion. Although limited, delegates have a certain level of policy influence in the NPC (Jiang, 2003; Truex, 2014).

Table 1. NPC Representation Descriptive Statistics, by Term

Category	11th NPC (2008-13)	12th NPC (2013-18)	13th NPC (2018-23)	14th NPC (2023-)	Average
Total	2987	2987	2980	2977	2983
<i>Demographics</i>					
Women	637 (21.3%)	699 (23.4%)	742 (24.9%)	790 (26.5%)	717 (24.0%)
Ethnic minorities	411 (13.8%)	409 (13.7%)	438 (14.7%)	442 (14.8%)	425 (14.0%)
Returned overseas Chinese	35	35	39	42	38
<i>Occupation</i>					
Frontline workers and farmers	246 (8.6%)	401 (13.4%)	468 (15.7%)	497 (16.7%)	403 (13.6%)
Professional technical personnel	574 (19.2%)	610 (20.4%)	613 (20.6%)	634 (21.3%)	607.8 (20.4%)
Party and government leading cadres	1249 (41.8%)	1042 (34.9%)	1011 (33.9%)	969 (32.5%)	106.8 (35.8%)
<i>Experience</i>					

First-time legislator	65.5%	62.1%	74.2%	73.2%	68.8%
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Note: This table compares legislators between the 11th NPC and the 14th NPC. The 13th NPC (highlighted) shows representation patterns generally consistent with historical averages, though with notable increases in women legislators (24.9% vs. 24.0% average), ethnic minorities (14.7% vs. 14.0% average), and frontline workers/farmers (15.7% vs. 13.6% average). The percentage of first-time legislators (74.2%) is significantly higher than the average (68.8%), indicating greater turnover in the 13th NPC. Party and government leading cadres representation (33.9%) is below the average (35.8%), showing a declining trend across terms.

We first take a look at the personnel of recent NPCs. By comparing descriptive statistics of legislators between the 11th NPC and the 14th NPC, Table X shows the 13th NPC qualifies as a representative for studying legislators’ bill sponsorship patterns for it shares similar characteristics with other NPCs.³ Specifically, in terms of demographics, the percentage of women legislators in the 13th NPC (24.9%) is close to the average (24.0%). The percentage of legislators who are ethnic minorities also mirrors the average (14.0%). In terms of occupation, the 13th NPC’s representation of frontline workers and farmers (15.7%) is higher than the average (13.6%). Professional technical personnel (20.6%) mirrors the average (20.4%). The percentage of party and government leading cadres (33.9%) is the only group that is less than the average (35.8%). In terms of political experience, the percentage of first-time legislators in the 13th NPC (74.2%) is significantly higher than the average (68.8%). Overall, the increase in the percentage of frontline workers and farmers, women legislators and first-time legislators indicates a trend toward greater inclusion of newer and more diverse representatives in the 13th NPC. The characteristics of the 14th NPC shows that the trend remains in the latest NPC.

Legislators have the freedom to decide whether to draft or submit a bill to the NPC or not. Contrary to what is widely believed, drafting a bill takes a significant amount of time and effort on the part of the sponsors, especially the leading sponsor. If an individual delegate’s bill aims to move forward to the promulgation process, it must have the signatures of at least 30 NPC delegates. Sponsors,

³ Changhao Wei, *(Still) Mostly Han Men: Demographics of the 14th NPC*, NPC OBSERVER. <https://npcobserver.com/2023/02/china-14th-npc-demographics/>. Accessed February 6, 2025.

working with government agencies and scholars, hold public conferences, conduct research trips to different localities, collect first-hand data, and participate in discussions with officials and representatives from relevant fields (Deng & Liu, 2017). On top of the work for drafting a bill, they also need to spend time and political capital to promote their proposed bills in order to acquire the 30 signatures (Hu, 2014).

Completing the process demands a serious commitment of time, effort, and political resources. Therefore, it is no surprise that in every NPC, only a fraction of legislators have strong enough motivations to push through the process. In the 13th NPC, 20.87% of legislators sponsored at least one bill. They are the legislators of interest in this study. More details on the bills sponsored in the 13th NPC is discussed in the Data section.

Once the bill sponsorship is done by legislators, the bill review process begins. For bills that are successfully sponsored in the NPC, central political elites in the NPC Standing Committee (NPCSC) decide whether they could pass as laws or policies behind a closed door. The NPCSC consists of ten review committees, each filled with full-time delegates who are experts in their respective areas.⁴ Their job is to meet frequently throughout the year to discuss what bills should be included in next year's legislative agenda. Some bills are deemed more important than others. In this case, high-level CCP leaders may intervene and promote their favored policies (Feng, Hou, & Liu, 2021). Bills that are not as important or urgent could be under evaluation for up to 10 years (Truex, 2018). In the end, favored bills will be included on a five-year legislative agenda as well as annual legislative work

⁴ The full list of review committees in the NPCSC consists of the following: Ethnic Affairs Committee, Constitution and Law Committee, Supervisory and Judicial Affairs Committee, Financial and Economic Affairs Committee, Education, Science, Culture and Public Health Committee, Foreign Affairs Committee, Overseas Chinese Affairs Committee, Environmental Protection and Resources Conservation Committee, Agriculture and Rural Affairs Committee, and Social Development Affairs Committee.

plans, both issued by the NPCSC. These plans prioritize proposed laws for deliberation and the eventual passage (Truex, 2018). But overall, all bills are taken seriously by the NPCSC and receive detailed feedback in a given time (Jiang, 2003; Truex, 2014).

In a nutshell, although the composition of each NPC is strictly orchestrated by the central government, delegates have the full discretion to decide: a) whether to sponsor a bill, b) the number of bills they would like to sponsor, and c) the subject matter of bills. While limited, they have certain influence on whether a bill eventually becomes a law. With the background knowledge of how the Chinese legislative system works and the role of NPC in the system in mind, we will introduce the research design and data more relevant to our hypothesis testing in the next section.

Data

The study evaluates both arguments in the context of the 13th Chinese NPC, with an original [dataset](#) that includes the biographical information of every delegate who has sponsored at least one bill in the 13th NPC between 2018 and 2022 (N=622) and all bills they sponsored in the time period (N=2209). Specifically, I identified the number of terms that each delegate has served in office (including the 13th NPC), delegates' party affiliation, gender, ethnicity, and the characteristics of their employment.

Due to information opaqueness, my data on sponsored bills contained only the names of the NPC delegates who initiated the bills, i.e., the leading sponsors. The names of other cosponsors are not publicly accessible.⁵ The lack of data on cosponsors' names do not undermine the empirical tests,

⁵ The *number* of cosponsors of each bill is accessible. But the number overall ranges from 30 to 33 except when a bill is cosponsored by delegates from the same province, in which case the number of cosponsors

because the goal is to identify those individuals with the capacity to signal their capability to the regime elites (the functional co-optation theory) or outsiders (the reputation-boost theory) by initiating bills and mobilizing other delegates to cosponsor with them.

Given that the NPC has a major change of personnel every five years, I collected bills limited in the 13th NPC to control for impacts potentially generated by the change of term. I collected all data from public government documents and the Internet.⁶

Outcome variable

The research design aims to examine whether the likelihood of delegates with different backgrounds advancing bills in policy areas that match their professional background increases, decreases, or remains unchanged as they gain seniority, i.e., serving more terms in office.

The outcome variable, professional congruence, is a dummy variable indicating whether there is a match between the subject matter of a bill and the occupation of the sponsor. A bill exhibits professional congruence if its content matches the professional background of its sponsor.

A major challenge arose when I tried to code the variable. There is no strict separation in between the legislative and executive branches of an authoritarian government by nature. This nature determines that a number of bills do not have a professional area to be positioned in due to the executive or party-affiliated background of their sponsors. Therefore, I first put delegates into three

equals to the number of delegates from that province. I excluded this factor because its variation is too small to generate significant impacts.

⁶ Out of the 2209 cases, 39 contain randomly missing data. The cases are handled with pairwise deletion, since their small amount is unlikely to cause bias in the results.

categories based on the characteristics of their occupation. The three categories are: a) delegates with a functional background; b) the main owners or chief executives officers of a private enterprise; c) delegates who work in the executive and party organizations without a functional background.

For the purpose of hypothesis testing, I further categorize the three groups into two: delegates with functional and non-functional background. Evidently, CEO delegates and delegates who work in the executive and party organizations without a functional background belong to the later group.

Then, I proceeded to code the outcome variable based on whether there is a match between the subject matter of a bill and the occupation of its sponsor. Delegates with functional backgrounds work in functional sectors, such as medical, legal, academic, and military industries. Delegates with a position in public office that require professional skills, such as public health departments or social affairs departments, are also included in this category. Their sponsored bills exhibit professional congruence if the subject matter of the bill matches their professional background.

The main owners or chief executives of private enterprises sponsor bills exhibiting professional congruence only when the bill is in issue areas that match their business sector or relates to general business operations.

Delegates who work in the executive and party organizations without functional backgrounds are officials in governments or members of the Chinese Communist Party working in the provincial- and county-level party branches. Due to the nature of their occupation, they are prohibited from taking positions in any social organizations, and therefore have no chance to be in a specific field. Their bills only exhibit professional congruence when regarding the governance of the locality.

Table 2. Examples of bills with professional congruence

Type of Sponsors	Sponsor's Name	Sponsor's Occupation	Bill Content	
Functional	Wu Zhiyong	Principal of Vocational College of Science and Technology in the city of Shijiazhuang	A bill on revising the Vocational Education Law	
	Liu Shoumin	Lawyer at the Dentons Law Offices	A bill on revising the Arbitration Law	
	Wang Xuanyu	Military Officer of People’s Liberation Army	A bill on revising the Military Facilities Protection Law	
	Geng Xuemei	Deputy Director General of the Civil Affairs Department in Anhui Province	A bill on drafting a Social Assistance Law	
Non-Functional	CEO	Liu Huaiping	CEO of Keda Clean Energy Corporate	A bill on revising the Environmental Protection Law
		Jiang Ming	CEO of Tianming Group	A bill on revising the Employment Contract Law
	Govt Executive & Party Member	Wang Nenggan	Secretary of the CCP Nongke Village branch in Baoan county, Daye, Hubei province	A bill on revising Villager’s Committees Organic Law

Note: This table showcases examples of professionally congruent bills across delegate types. Functional delegates demonstrate professional congruence when their bills align with their occupational expertise. CEO delegates exhibit professional congruence when bills align with their business sector. Government executives and party cadres demonstrate professional congruence through bills addressing local governance structures.

Table 2 shows examples of professionally congruent bills across delegate types, following the above principle. As specified, functional delegates demonstrate professional congruence when their bills align with their occupational expertise. In the table, Wu Zhiyong, a vocational college principal, sponsors education legislation, directly leveraging his professional knowledge. Similarly, Liu Shoumin, a lawyer, sponsors a bill on arbitration law, drawing on his legal expertise. Military officer Wang Xuanyu and civil affairs administrator Geng Xuemei likewise sponsor bills directly related to their professional domains.

For non-functional delegates, CEO delegates exhibit professional congruence when bills align with their business sector. Liu Huaiping, heading a clean energy corporation, sponsors an environmental protection bill that relates to his industry's concerns. Jiang Ming's bill on employment contract law

represents a case where a CEO engages with labor regulations affecting their enterprise.

Government executives and party members demonstrate professional congruence through bills addressing local governance structures, as exemplified by Wang Nenggan, a village-level party secretary, who sponsors legislation on village committees.

A similar analysis approach can be found in Makse's (2021) examinations of legislators' background and policymaking success, Battista's (2012) as well as Hamm, Hedlund, and Post's (2011) examinations of legislators' background and committee service in democratic contexts. In authoritarian contexts, Malesky and Schuler (2010b) use a similar approach to examine legislators' background and the type of questions that delegates raise in the Vietnamese National Assembly; Feng, Hou, and Liu (2024) study female delegates and bills representing women's interests.

Explanatory variable

The variable of interest, delegates' terms in office, is a continuous variable that records the number of terms a delegate has served in office, including the 13th NPC. In the dataset, the range of delegates' number of terms in office is between one and five. Each term lasts for five years.

Control variables

I included the bill inclusion as a major control variable. For bills being successfully sponsored in the NPC, central political elites in the NPC Standing Committee (NPCSC) decide whether they could pass as laws or policies behind a closed door. Therefore, the status of bill inclusion is a key indicator for the policy preferences of regime elites, who have the final say on whether a bill can be on the legislative agendas next year.

I recorded the status of bill inclusion using the annual legislative plans between 2019 and 2023, which show whether a bill sponsored between 2018 and 2022 is on next year’s legislative agenda. A discernible preference toward a specific type of bills sends signals to delegates about what bills they should sponsor if they seek to maximize their policy influence.

I also included variables on the basic biographical information of delegates, including gender, ethnicity, and party membership to control for the effects of delegates’ terms in office on the subject matter of the sponsored bills. Makse (2021) finds that minority party legislators tend to maximize their policy influence by advancing policies in areas that match their professional background in the U.S. Congress. Likewise, in an authoritarian context where policy influence is possible, delegates from minority ethnic or gender groups as well as minority parties are likely to demonstrate similar behavioral patterns. Given the seats in the 13th NPC are predominantly occupied by the dominant ethnic group, Han, and the dominant party, CCP, I coded the last two as binary variables. In the next section, I present descriptive and inferential results based on this research design.

Who sponsored what types of bills?

Table 3. Bill Characteristics and Sponsor Demographics, by Delegate Type

Characteristics	Functional	Non-functional	CEO	Govt Executives & Party Cadres
<i>Bill Characteristics</i>				
Total (N)	1326	883	520	363
Bills with Professional Congruence (%)	65.8	30.2	32.7	26.7
Bill Inclusion (%)	56.0	52.9	49.8	57.3
Bills per Legislator (N)	3.7	3.4	5.0	2.3
<i>Sponsor Demographics</i>				
Total (N)	359	263	105	158
CCP Member (%)	50.7	71.2	68.3	75.4
Female (%)	46.8	35.7	37.1	33.6
Ethnic Minority (%)	9.5	20	23.7	14.9

First-time Legislator (%)	63.9	47.1	32.5	68.0
Terms in Office (%)	1.4	1.5	1.7	1.3

Note: This table presents a comparison of bill characteristics and sponsor demographics across different delegate types in the 13th NPC. Functional delegates show higher rates of professional congruence (65.8%) compared to non-functional delegates (30.2%). CEO delegates sponsor the most bills per legislator (5.0) despite having the lowest bill inclusion rate (49.8%). Government executives and party cadres have the lowest professional congruence (26.7%) but the highest bill inclusion rate (57.3%). Demographic patterns reveal higher female representation among functional delegates (46.8%), higher ethnic minority representation among CEOs (23.7%), and notable differences in CCP membership and legislative experience across delegate types.

Table 3 reveals multiple descriptive findings in both delegates' legislative activities and characteristics of bills they sponsored. In terms of total number of bills, functional delegates sponsored the largest share (N=1,326), substantially more than either CEOs (N=520) or government executives and party cadres (N=363), with the latter two non-functional groups collectively sponsoring 883 bills. Given that delegates have the full discretion to decide the number of bills they would like to sponsor, the difference in bill numbers suggests that functional delegates demonstrate a higher level of legislative engagement. On top of that, they also demonstrate the strongest alignment between their professional expertise and legislative activities, with 65.8% of their bills showing professional congruence. This high congruence rate stands in contrast to non-functional delegates, whose bills show substantially lower professional congruence (30.2%). This finding provides initial support to Hypothesis 1. Within the non-functional group, CEO delegates' bills show slightly higher professional congruence (32.7%) compared to government executives and party cadres (26.7%). However, we do not have enough evidence to claim any linear relation between delegates' seniority and bills' professional congruence by just looking at the descriptive results.

Meanwhile, we also see positive signals supporting Hypothesis 2 when examining the pattern of professional congruence alongside non-functional delegates' legislative behaviors. According to the table, CEO delegates are in fact the most productive legislators, sponsoring an average of five bills per legislator, which is significantly higher than functional delegates (3.7 bills) and government

executives and party cadres (2.3 bills). However, despite their high productivity, only about one-third of CEO-sponsored bills align with their professional expertise, suggesting that they frequently venture beyond their business domains in legislative activities. Besides, CEO-sponsored bills show the lowest proportion of first-time legislator sponsorship (32.5%) and the highest average terms in office (1.7 terms), indicating that experienced CEO delegates are more active in sponsoring bills across various policy domains than the less experienced. The combination of high productivity and low congruence, especially among senior CEO legislators, provides a positive signal for Hypothesis 2.

Conversely, numbers on government executives and party cadres send out mixed signals. As mentioned above, they demonstrate the broadest policy exposure across the three groups by sponsoring the least amount of professionally congruent bills (26.7%). They show the highest proportion of first-time legislator sponsorship (68.0%) and lowest average number of terms (1.3), suggesting that most of the bills without professional congruence are sponsored by junior delegates. Yet, they end up maintaining the highest bill inclusion rate (57.3%). In contrast, CEO delegates have the lowest bill inclusion rate (49.8%), despite their overall high productivity and a bill professional congruence rate that, although low (32.7%), is still higher than that of government executives and party cadres (26.7%). The mixed signals suggest that government executives and party cadres may benefit from institutional advantages or political networks that facilitate bill inclusion regardless of professional focus. This suggestion indicates that while both non-functional groups engage in broad policy areas as predicted by Hypothesis 2, they may do so for different reasons. CEOs potentially for reputation-building through diverse policy engagement, and government executives possibly due to their institutional position within the political system that affords them greater success despite less experience and professional alignment. Unfortunately, the scope of our current data is not sufficient

to thoroughly test the second theory, nor do we have enough qualitative evidence to substantiate our interpretation. This study will therefore continue to focus primarily on testing Hypothesis 2 for CEO delegates, with future research directed toward a more comprehensive examination of government executives and party cadres.

Last but not least, the demographic control variables also reveal patterns that align with our expectations derived from Makse's (2021) findings on minority representatives. Female delegates, who constitute a demographic minority in the NPC, show a markedly higher engagement level among functional delegates (46.8%) compared to non-functional delegates (35.7%), suggesting they may strategically leverage professional expertise to enhance their policy influence. Interestingly, the distribution of ethnic minority delegates presents an inverse pattern, with significantly higher engagement among non-functional delegates (20.0%), particularly CEOs (23.7%), compared to functional delegates (9.5%). This suggests minority delegates may pursue different pathways to policy influence than their Han counterparts. Notably, CCP membership also displays an inverse pattern to gender and ethnicity, with substantially higher rates among non-functional delegates (71.2%) compared to functional delegates (50.7%). This finding seems to align with our expectation that in an authoritarian context, those from non-dominant groups (whether by gender, ethnicity, or party) may adopt distinctive strategies to maximize their limited policy influence, with professional background playing a crucial moderating role in this relationship.

To sum up, the descriptive evidence provides preliminary support for both hypotheses. Functional delegates tend to sponsor professionally congruent bills (Hypothesis 1) and experienced non-functional delegates', especially CEO delegates', strategic diversification across policy domains (Hypothesis 2). Findings regarding bill sponsorship patterns for delegates from the non-dominant

groups seem to agree with our expectation that they may adopt distinctive strategies to maximize their policy influence within an authoritarian context, with their professional background moderating how these strategies manifest.

I now turn to inferential analysis to formally test our hypotheses regarding how professional background and legislative experience shape bill sponsorship behavior, while also examining how demographic factors like gender, ethnicity, and party membership interact with these patterns.

Logistic estimates of the correlation between delegates' terms in office and bills' professional congruence

I use a binomial specification to further analyze the relationship between *professional congruence* and *delegates' terms in office*. The outcome variable, *professional congruence*, is a dummy variable indicating whether there is a match between the subject matter of the bill and the occupation of the leading sponsor. A bill exhibits professional congruence if the subject matter of the bill matches the professional background of the leading sponsor. The variable of interest, *delegates' terms in office*, is a continuous variable that records the number of terms a delegate has served, including the 13th NPC. In the dataset, the range of *delegates' terms in office* is between one and five. Transforming the variable of interest using a natural log is common when the original data do not reflect a normal distribution, but given that in this case there are only 5 values for the variable of interest, I avoid complicating hypothesis testing by skipping this operation. To test whether the relationship between terms in office and professional congruence varies systematically across delegate types, I include an interaction term between delegate background and terms in office in the model.

Hypothesis 1 predicts a positive coefficient for terms in office among functional delegates and an increase in professional congruence with greater legislative experience. Hypothesis 2 predicts a negative coefficient for terms in office and a decrease in professional congruence as non-functional delegates, especially CEO delegates, gain legislative experience.

Table 4 presents the estimates of the model. Model 1 examines only bills sponsored by functional delegates. Models 2-4 focus on bills sponsored by non-functional delegates. Model 2 includes bills sponsored by non-functional delegates combined. Model 3 focuses specifically on CEO delegates. Model 4 on government executives and party cadres. Model 5 uses the complete dataset and incorporates interaction terms to directly compare how terms in office affect professional congruence across different delegate types.

For functional delegates (Model 1), each additional term in office is associated with a significant increase in the likelihood of sponsoring professionally congruent bills ($\beta = 0.319$, $p < 0.01$). This positive relationship aligns with our descriptive analysis and strongly supports Hypothesis 1.

Non-functional delegates demonstrate the opposite pattern, as expected. For CEO delegates (Model 3), the coefficient for terms in office is negative and significant ($\beta = -0.208$, $p < 0.1$), indicating that more experienced CEOs are less likely to sponsor bills related to their business background.

Similarly, government executives and party cadres (Model 4) show a negative, though not statistically significant, relationship between terms and professional congruence ($\beta = -0.149$). These results provide initial support for Hypothesis 2, suggesting that non-functional delegates, particularly CEOs, increasingly diversify beyond their professional domains as they gain experience.

Table 4. Logistic estimates of the correlation between delegate's terms in office and bill's professional congruence

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>				
	Professional Congruence				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Number of terms	0.319*** (0.074)	-0.180** (0.085)	-0.208* (0.120)	-0.149 (0.156)	0.267*** (0.072)
Bill inclusion	-0.160 (0.123)	-0.395** (0.154)	-0.728*** (0.209)	-0.012 (0.252)	-0.259*** (0.096)
Female	-0.277** (0.128)	-0.219 (0.180)	-0.571** (0.270)	0.922*** (0.285)	-0.303*** (0.103)
Han Ethnicity	0.159 (0.203)	0.844*** (0.259)	1.872*** (0.468)	-0.449 (0.340)	0.524*** (0.154)
Chinese Communist Party	1.079*** (0.131)	0.200 (0.179)	0.166 (0.233)	1.351*** (0.373)	0.753*** (0.105)
CEO					-0.634** (0.271)
Govt Executive and Party Member					-1.310*** (0.271)
Number of terms × CEO					-0.529*** (0.130)
Number of terms × Govt Executive/Party Cadres					-0.399** (0.159)
Constant	-0.278 (0.251)	-1.111*** (0.396)	-1.532** (0.656)	-1.775*** (0.574)	-0.310 (0.219)
Observations	1,304	866	508	358	2,170
Log Likelihood	-785.856	-507.297	-278.535	-197.071	-1,300.340
Akaike Inf. Crit.	1,583.712	1,026.594	569.070	406.142	2,620.680
<i>Note:</i>			*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01		

The interaction model (Model 5) provides the most robust results by directly comparing how terms influence professional congruence across delegate types. The positive and significant main effect of terms ($\beta = 0.267$, $p < 0.01$) confirms that functional delegates, the reference category in the model, have a 30.6% increase in the odds of sponsoring professionally congruent bills for each additional

term.⁷ The significant negative interactions for both CEO delegates ($\beta = -0.529$, $p < 0.01$) and government executives ($\beta = -0.399$, $p < 0.05$) reveal that these groups exhibit the opposite pattern from functional delegates. CEO delegates have a 23.1% decrease in the odds of sponsoring professionally congruent bills with each additional term.⁸ The number is a 12.4% decrease for government executives and party cadres.⁹ The finding strongly supports Hypothesis 2.

In terms of control variables, bill inclusion demonstrates a consistent negative relationship with professional congruence across models, most pronounced for CEO delegates ($\beta = -0.728$, $p < 0.01$). This indicates that CEO-sponsored bills that are included in legislative plans are approximately 51.7% less likely to be professionally congruent than those not included in plans.¹⁰ This pattern points to the possibility of log-rolling behaviors. Unfortunately, we do not have enough data on co-sponsors to validate the existence of reciprocity networks among delegates. Future research should collect comprehensive co-sponsorship data across multiple NPC terms to identify potential logrolling patterns and examine the possibility of delegates building cross-professional alliances to increase their collective policy influence within the constraints of an authoritarian legislature.

Besides, female government executives and party cadres demonstrate a strong positive relationship with professional congruence ($\beta = 0.922$, $p < 0.01$), being about 151.4% more likely to sponsor professionally congruent bills, while female delegates in other background types shows the opposite pattern ($\beta = -0.277$, $p < 0.05$ for functional; $\beta = -0.571$, $p < 0.01$ for CEOs).¹¹ This finding is not

⁷ The percentage change in odds is calculated as $e^{0.267} - 1 = 0.306$ or 30.6% increase in odds per additional term.

⁸ The total effect is calculated by combining the main effect with the interaction term: $0.267 - 0.529 = -0.262$, resulting in $1 - e^{-0.262} = 0.231$ or 23.1% decrease in odds per additional term.

⁹ The total effect is calculated as $0.267 - 0.399 = -0.132$, resulting in $1 - e^{-0.132} = 0.124$ or 12.4% decrease in odds per additional term.

¹⁰ The percentage decrease in odds is calculated as $1 - e^{(-0.728)} = 1 - 0.483 = 0.517$ or approximately 51.7%.

¹¹ The percentage increase in odds is calculated as $e^{(0.922)} - 1 = 2.514 - 1 = 1.514$ or approximately 151.4%.

consistent with the implication derived from our descriptive finding, which is higher female engagement level among functional delegates (46.8% vs. 35.7% for non-functional delegates) probably points to a higher likelihood for this group to sponsor professionally congruent bills, leveraging their background to maximize their policy influence. On the contrary, it suggests that female delegates may take the opportunity of bill sponsorship to address issues affecting women’s interests over forwarding bills matching their professional background.

This gendered pattern in legislative priorities is well-established in the literature. For instance, [Mendelberg, Karpowitz and Goedert \(2014\)](#) argue that women's shared social positioning and experiences result in distinct policy preferences, with female legislators being more oriented toward caring for vulnerable populations including the poor, elderly, and children. Building on this understanding, [Clayton's \(2021\)](#) comprehensive review demonstrates how these differences manifest in policy prioritization, with women legislators consistently showing more divergent political preferences than men and placing greater emphasis on women's rights, public health, and poverty alleviation issues across different political contexts. In a more recent and relevant context, Feng, Hou, and Liu (2024) found that in the 12th NPC, women sponsored more than half (58.87%) of bills related to women's interests despite only holding 23.4% of seats. In their study, "women's interests" were broadly defined as bills containing keywords related to "women, girl, child/children, campus, school, minor, birth, birth control, marriage, divorce, domestic violence, or family" (p. 71).

Table 5. Distribution of committee membership among female and male legislators, by delegate type

Female Legislators				Male Legislators			
Type	Committee	N	%	Type	Committee	N	%
Functional	Constitution and Law	93	36	Functional	Constitution and Law	65	33.2
	Environmental Protection	42	16.3		Environmental Protection	36	18.4

Commented [1]: Mendelberg, Tali, Christopher F. Karpowitz, and Nicholas Goedert. 2014. "Does Descriptive Representation Facilitate Women's Distinctive Voice? How Gender Composition and Decision Rules Affect Deliberation." *American Journal of Political Science* 58(2): 291-306.

Commented [2]: Clayton, Amanda. 2021. "How Do Electoral Gender Quotas Affect Policy?" *Annual Review of Political Science* 24: 235-252.

	Social Development Affairs	35	13.6		Financial and Economic Affairs	32	16.3
	Constitution and Law	43	26.9		Constitution and Law	52	27.4
CEO	Financial and Economic Affairs	43	26.9	CEO	Financial and Economic Affairs	43	22.6
	Education and Public Health	35	21.9		Environmental Protection	27	14.2
	Constitution and Law	26	31.3		Constitution and Law	57	31.1
Govt Executive & Party Cadre	Financial and Economic Affairs	19	22.9	Govt Executive & Party Cadre	Financial and Economic Affairs	38	20.8
	Social Development Affairs	18	21.7		Education and Public Health	29	15.8

Note: This table shows the top three committees that female and male legislators serve on, broken down by delegate type. Numbers indicate the count and percentage of bills sponsored within each committee. While Constitution and Law Committee dominates across all delegate types and genders, female and male legislators show different third committee preferences, with female delegates more likely to prioritize Social Development Affairs and Education and Public Health committees than their male counterparts.

A further analysis of the committee distribution and bill sponsorship patterns in our dataset provides initial evidence in line with the above literature. While the Constitution and Law Committee dominates as the primary choice across all delegate types and genders, female delegates' secondary and tertiary committee preferences reveal their distinctive policy priorities (Table 5). Female functional delegates and female government executives both prioritize Social Development Affairs (13.6% and 21.7% respectively) among their top committees, while female CEOs uniquely emphasize Education, Science, Culture and Public Health (21.9%). These patterns directly align with Mendelberg, Karpowitz, and Goedert's (2014) argument that women legislators prioritize caring for vulnerable populations, as both committees typically handle issues affecting women, children, families, and marginalized groups.

Among the 935 bills sponsored by female delegates, 53.6% are not professionally congruent. Following the coding strategy in Feng, Hou, and Liu (2024), we see consistent ranking of the

percentage of bills pertaining to women's interests among these bills in Table 6, with government executives and party members demonstrating the highest proportion (12.0%), followed by functional delegates (6.6%) and CEOs (3.8%). This pattern reveals that female government executives, who showed a positive relationship with professional congruence in our regression model, also exhibit the strongest tendency to address women's interests when they venture beyond their professional domains.

Table 6. Distribution of women's interest bills among non-professionally congruent bills by sponsor background

Sponsor Background	Total Non-congruent Bills	Women's Interest Bills	
		N	%
Functional	258	17	6.6
CEO	160	6	3.8
Govt Executive & Party Cadres	83	10	12

Note: This table shows the proportion of women's interest bills among non-professionally congruent bills sponsored by female legislators, broken down by sponsor background type. Government Executives and Party Cadres show the highest rate of sponsoring women's interest bills (12%) when venturing beyond their professional domains, followed by Functional delegates (6.6%) and CEOs (3.8%), suggesting different patterns of gender-related issue prioritization across delegate types.

Moreover, female government executives maintain this focus on women's interests even within their professionally congruent bills, with an impressive 17.9% of these bills addressing women's issues, the highest rate across all delegate types and congruence categories. This explains the contradictory finding we see from the regression analysis, where female government executives uniquely showed a positive relationship with professional congruence while other female delegates showed negative relationships. Female functional delegates show moderate engagement with women's interests in both congruent (9.4%) and non-congruent bills (6.6%), while female CEOs demonstrate relatively low rates regardless of congruence type (3.0% and 3.8%). Rather than contradicting our framework, these findings suggest that female government executives' positive relationship with professional

congruence reflects their unique ability to integrate women's interests directly into their professional domain, allowing them to advance gender-related priorities while maintaining professional focus.

Another unexpected finding is the strong positive relationship between Han ethnicity and professional congruence among CEO delegates ($\beta = 1.872, p < 0.01$) and non-functional delegates generally ($\beta = 0.844, p < 0.01$), despite our descriptive analysis showing higher ethnic minority engagement level in these groups in our descriptive analysis. This contrast suggests that while ethnic minorities are more active in bill sponsorship among non-functional delegates (20.0% vs. 9.5% for functional delegates), they are significantly less likely to sponsor bills related to their professional expertise than their Han counterparts. This pattern is similar to what we saw in female delegates' bill sponsorship. It may reflect ethnic minority delegates' efforts to establish broader political influence beyond their professional domains, potentially using their legislative platform to address issues affecting their ethnic communities rather than focusing solely on their business or bureaucratic expertise. We will examine if this pattern exists by looking at the specific policy areas these delegates engage with.

In conclusion, the inferential analysis and the follow-up content analysis provide strong support for both hypotheses, showing that functional delegates increasingly sponsor professionally congruent bills with experience, while non-functional delegates, especially CEOs, show the opposite pattern. Unexpected findings reveal important demographic dynamics. Female government executives uniquely sponsor professionally congruent bills that address women's interests, while ethnic minorities in non-functional roles are less likely to sponsor professionally congruent bills than their Han counterparts.

Conclusion

Contrary to how an authoritarian legislature is widely perceived, the legislators in an authoritarian legislature without elections, Chinese National People's Congress demonstrates tremendously different bill sponsorship behaviors. This study provides compelling evidence of distinctive patterns among delegates across different professional backgrounds and experience levels. Descriptive findings reveal that functional delegates demonstrate higher legislative engagement and stronger alignment between their expertise and sponsored bills than non-functional delegates. Inferential analyses confirm that functional delegates increasingly sponsor professionally congruent bills as they gain experience, while non-functional delegates, particularly CEOs, diversify beyond their professional domains with increased legislative tenure. Demographic factors further complicate these patterns, with female government executives uniquely sponsoring professionally congruent bills addressing women's interests, while ethnic minorities in non-functional roles demonstrate lower professional congruence than their Han counterparts.

Overall, these findings challenge conventional understandings of authoritarian legislatures as merely rubber-stamp institutions, instead revealing them as complex arenas where delegates strategically navigate professional expertise, political considerations, and demographic representation to maximize their policy influence.

There are several data limitations to this study. First, the absence of co-sponsorship data does not undermine the empirical tests, but it does prevent comprehensive analysis of potential logrolling behaviors among delegates, limiting our ability to test the reputation-boost theory's further predictions regarding reciprocity among delegates; future research should collect and analyze co-sponsorship networks to examine how delegates build alliances across professional domains.

Second, the analysis is restricted to a single legislative term (13th NPC), preventing examination of how institutional changes across terms might affect delegate behavior; longitudinal studies spanning multiple NPC terms would provide more robust insights into how structural reforms influence bill sponsorship patterns. Third, we lack qualitative data such as interviews or legislators' memoirs, making it impossible to definitively validate the motivations behind delegates' legislative behaviors. Future research should incorporate qualitative evidence to further validate our findings, particularly regarding why experienced CEO delegates increasingly sponsor bills outside their professional domains despite lower inclusion rates for such bills.

Lastly, while sharing a non-functional background, CEO delegates and Government Executives/Party Members exhibit distinct sponsorship patterns, with CEOs being significantly more productive (5.0 bills per legislator versus 2.3) yet less successful in achieving bill inclusion (49.8% versus 57.3%). Further research should investigate why Government executives and party cadres achieve higher bill inclusion rates despite lower professional congruence and whether these differences stem from institutional advantages, political networks, or strategic considerations that our current data cannot fully illuminate.

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